- Monitor and record vital sign and intake and output.
- Check cough and gag reflex to prevent aspiration.
- Administer IV fluids to maintain hydration.
- Providing Suctioning to maintain airway
- Provide eye, skin and mouth care to prevent tissue damage.

2.9 Epilepsy/Seizure Disorders

Definition: Seizures (also known as epileptic seizures and, if recurrent, epilepsy) are defined as a sudden alteration in normal brain activity that causes distinct changes in behavior and body function. Seizures are thought to result from disturbances in the cells of the brain that cause cells to give off abnormal, recurrent, uncontrolled electrical discharges.

Classification

The International League Against Epilepsy developed an international classification of epileptic seizures that divides seizures into two major classes: partial-onset seizures and generalized-onset seizures.

1. Simple-partial seizures can have motor, somato sensory, psychic, or autonomic symptoms without impairment of consciousness.
2. Complex-partial seizures have an impairment (but not a loss) of consciousness with simple-partial features, automatisms, or impairment of consciousness only.
3. Generalized seizures have a loss of consciousness with convulsive or non convulsive behaviors.
4. Simple-partial seizures can progress to complex-partial seizures, and complex-partial seizures can secondarily become generalized.

Causes

The etiology may be unknown or due to one of the following:

- Trauma to head or brain resulting in scar tissue or cerebral atrophy
- Tumor in the brain
- Cranial surgery
- Metabolic disorders (hypocalcemia, hypoglycemia)
- Drug toxicity, such as theophylline, lidocaine, penicillin
- CNS infection
- Circulatory disorders
- Drug withdrawal states (alcohol, barbiturates)
- Congenital neuro degenerative disorders.
- Non epileptogenic behaviors, which can emulate seizures but have a psychogenic, rather than an organic, origin

Signs and Symptoms

Manifestations are related to the area of the brain involved in the seizure activity and may range from single abnormal sensations, aberrant motor activity, altered consciousness or personality to loss of consciousness and convulsive movements.

1. Impaired consciousness
2. Disturbed muscle tone or movement
3. Disturbances of behavior, mood, sensation, or perception
4. Disturbances of autonomic functions.

Diagnostic Evaluation

- EEG (Electroencephalography) – locates epileptic focus, spread, intensity, and duration; helps classify seizure type
- MRI, CT scan–to identify lesion that may be cause of seizure
- Neuropsychological studies–to evaluate for behavioral disturbances

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